by the Lokniti-CSDS survey. The battle for their vote is likely to continue this election, particularly as 1.4 million voters will cast their ballot for the first time. Unemployment and migration remain key issues as well. In a startling fact that came out in the caste survey, only 4.95 per cent of Bihar's population has jobs. The new schemes worth Rs 62,000 crore for Bihar's youth address this. The PM is also set to inaugurate the Jan Nayak Karpoori Thakur Skill University, which will have industry-oriented courses and vocational training.

The SWOT Analysis

STRENGTHS: Nitish's enduring EBC and women support base, and now Chirag's Paswan vote; strong welfare architecture; BJP's disciplined organisation and Modi's brand equity

WEAKNESSES: Voter fatigue with 20 years of incumbency; Nitish's waning charisma and health; internal disquiet over leadership ambiguity; restlessness among youth over jobs and migration

OPPORTUNITIES: Consolidate the youth and women's vote across castes, while retaining Nitish's somewhat committed EBC vote bank

THREATS: A united MGB narrative or a strong third force in Prashant Kishor, which could erode margins

MGB: Tejashwi's Broad Appeal

In 2020, as the then newly anointed chief of the RJD, Tejashwi almost pulled off the impossible—turning a tired Opposition into a movement built around one audacious promise: a million government jobs. This time, the 35-year-old has to do one better, take the party as well as the MGB across the finish line. The challenge remains the same: to expand RJD support beyond the traditional Muslim-Yadav vote base that gives him a head start of a committed 30 per cent vote but not enough seats for a simple majority in the House.

So, Tejashwi is courting not just Dalits and Mahadalits, but also chipping at Nitish's EBC vote. Last month, the MGB announced an Atipichhada Nyay Sankalp, which proposes an EBC Atrocities Prevention Act, raising EBC quota in local bodies from 20 per cent to 30 per cent and residential land grants for landless EBC/SC/ST/OBC households. It also intends to tap youth disenchantment with unemployment and migration, and wooing women with financial incentives.

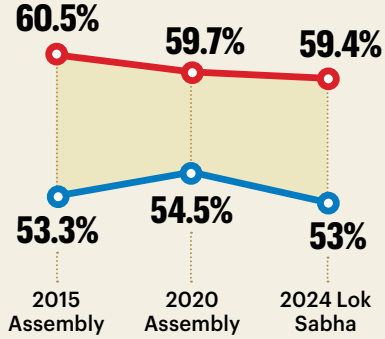
Its MGB partner Congress, meanwhile, stands reinvigorated by Rahul Gandhi's vote *chori* campaign in response to the Special Intensive Revision of Bihar's electoral rolls, and the subsequent Voter Adhikar Yatra. Once regarded as the weak link in the grand alliance, winning just 19 out of the 70 seats it contested in 2020, the party this time appears willing to contest fewer but strategically chosen seats. It also has a new state president in Rajesh Kumar, who is from the numerically significant Ravidas (SC) community. Of the MGB's Left partners, while the CPI and the CPI(M) add committed cadre votes, the CPI(ML) commands considerable sway in parts of south and central Bihar, and actually has the highest vote share in its territory among all MGB constituents. Mukesh Sahani's Vikassheel Insaan Party (VIP) is another ally with proven street strength. But limited reach is a bane for all of them. Right now, with seat talks also on testy ground, it is Tejashwi's lot to carry both the hopes and the burdens of Opposition unity. The young see in him a version of themselves: angry but polite, ambitious but wary. Yet charisma is never enough; it must translate into numbers.

The RJD is tapping into youth disenchantment with a promise of jobs; Congress, fresh off its voter rights yatra, supports its push for expanded quotas

X-FACTOR
WOMEN VOTERS

BALLOT POWER

From 1951 to 2005, the men ruled. The tide turned in 2010, when female turnout (54.5%) surpassed male turnout (51.1%) for the first time



In a state where caste long dictated loyalty, gender is emerging as a powerful new axis at the hustings